

Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD)

1. Definition

COPD is a disease that affects smokers and/or people who breathe smoky/polluted air. It is easily overlooked: patients present with infections whose recurrent nature escapes attention because they are examined each time by a different doctor. We therefore need to determine the history of lung infections to determine whether they are recurrent. The presence of COPD should also be considered in people with shortness of breath.

2. Diagnosis

COPD should be considered if the patient is over 35 years of age and a smoker/former smoker or is exposed to smoky or polluted atmospheres and has frequent lung infections or shortness of breath/wheezing on exertion (activity).

The following symptoms should be sought on examination:

- ❖ Chronic cough (daily for at least 3 months with no sign of tuberculosis)
- ❖ Regular expectorations, especially during wetter/cooler seasons.
- ❖ Shortness of breath and/or wheezing, especially on exertion.
- ❖ Repeated lung infections (3 or more in the last 2 years may suggest COPD but are not sufficient for diagnosis)
- ❖ Chest pain is rare.

3. Support

- Assess severity: pulse, A.T., respiratory rate, temperature, shortness of breath, cyanosis.
- If breathlessness worsens: give bronchodilators and oral steroids (salbutamol via an inhalation chamber)
- Referral to a district hospital for ECP and further investigations.